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IEC 61499 Compliant Web-based IDE for Function Block Design

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List of Acronyms

CPPS	Cyber-Physical Production Systems
FBD	Function Block Diagram
ICS	Industrial Control Systems
IDE	Integrated Development Environment
PLC	Programmable Logic Controller
RTE	Runtime Environment
SOA	Service-Oriented Architectures
UI	User Interface

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Context

Cyber-Physical Production Systems (CPPS) [6] are complex systems that integrate physical processes with digital technologies to optimise production processes. Several software engineering approaches and technologies are utilised in the development and operation of CPPS. One of such approaches is Function Block Diagram (FBD) [2], which is a graphical programming language used in industrial automation and control systems. FBD uses graphical function blocks to represent the logic and control of a system. The function blocks are connected in a network to form a control program. One of the benefits of FBD is that it provides a visual representation of the control logic, which can be easier to understand and debug than traditional textual programming languages. FBD is also modular, which means that function blocks can be reused in multiple programs, reducing development time and improving code maintainability. Also, FBD is often used in conjunction with Programmable Logic Controllers (PLCs) to control machinery and processes in manufacturing and other industrial applications [7, 8]. FBD programs can be created and edited using specialised software tools that allow for the creation and manipulation of function blocks [16].

In industrial automation, it is common to use the IEC 61499 standard, which defines an event-driven FBD approach to designing control software [11]. Unlike traditional PLC programming languages, IEC 61499 emphasizes modularity, reusability, and explicit separation of events and data, allowing developers to design complex distributed systems in a scalable and maintainable way. Function blocks define both algorithms and interfaces for inputs, outputs, and events, making them ideal for CPPS development [3]. This approach is particularly suitable for distributed automation systems, where control logic must respond to events generated by multiple devices or sensors in real time. An example of such a function block interface is shown in Figure 2.1, highlighting the event inputs, outputs, and data connections that enable flexible interaction between system components.

While Runtime Environments (RTEs) enable the execution of function blocks compliant with the standard, Integrated Development Environments (IDEs) are used to design, create, and deploy

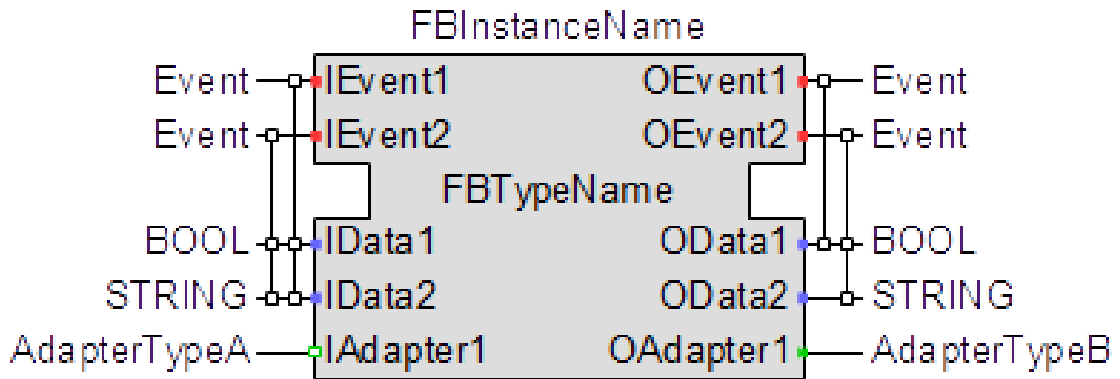


Figure 1.1: IEC 61499 function block interface [4]

function block pipelines to **CPPS**. These **IDEs** offer an User Interface (**UI**) with features and tools that facilitate the development, testing, and deployment of IEC 61499-compliant control systems. They are graphical editors, like shown in Figure 1.2, for creating function block diagrams with simulation capabilities and additional functionalities to streamline the development process.

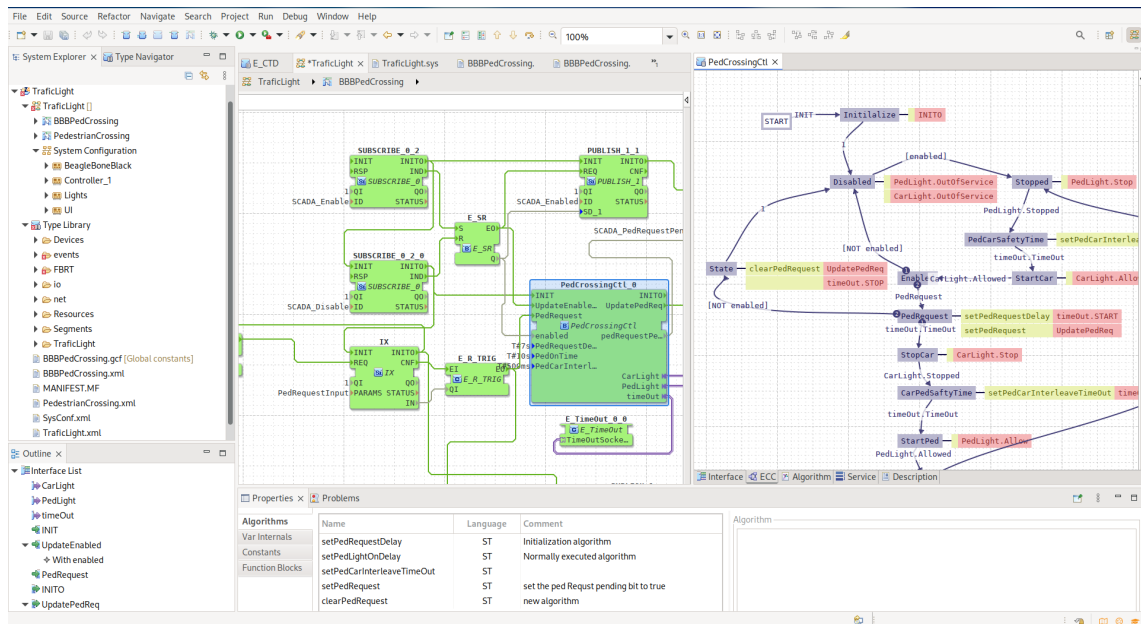


Figure 1.2: 4diac IDE [1]

1.2 Motivation

The evolution of **CPPS** has increased the demand for flexible and intelligent control solutions capable of integrating physical processes with digital technologies. **FBD** and the IEC 61499 standard offer a structured, modular approach to building such distributed automation systems. To fully leverage these benefits, development tools must evolve alongside industrial needs, supporting more accessible, collaborative, and scalable workflows.

1.3 Problem

Existing *IEC 61499* development environments are predominantly desktop-based and lack modern capabilities such as remote access, real-time collaboration, and seamless integration with cloud infrastructures. These limitations hinder efficient development, maintenance, and deployment of control applications within distributed **CPPS**. As a result, current tools fall short in supporting the flexibility, scalability required by certain modern industrial automation systems. Their complexity further complicates their usage for more basic needs.

1.4 Research Questions

This research seeks to investigate how modern web technologies can be leveraged to enhance the development, deployment, and operation of *IEC 61499*-compliant systems. This study is guided by the following main research question:

How can we design **IDEs** that enhance the development, deployment, and collaboration processes for *IEC 61499* applications in distributed **CPPS**, addressing the limitations of traditional desktop-based environments?

To further refine the scope, the following sub-question is proposed:

What architectural and technological requirements must be considered when designing an **IDE** for *IEC 61499*?

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This chapter reviews prior work related to *IEC 61499*-based development and the used IDEs. The goal is to better understand the landscape, which will then allow the critical review of the state of the art.

2.1 Methodology

A systematic literature review approach was adopted, the objective was to collect, screen, and analyze studies addressing *IEC 61499* development tools, function blocks, CPPS, and development environments, to then critically reflect upon their findings to help the writing of this dissertation and the planning of the final product.

2.1.1 Search and Selection

The search was conducted in digital libraries *ScienceDirect*, *IEEE Xplore*, *ACM Digital Library*, among others, as well as research paper aggregators like *Semantic Scholar*, *Scopus* and *Web of Science* using combinations of the following terms:

- *IEC 61499*
- FBD
- IDE
- CPPS

Following the search, a manual review process was conducted to refine and validate the results. Titles and abstracts were first screened to understand the relevance of the articles with respect to this dissertation. The publications were then examined in greater detail through full-text review, the reference lists of selected papers were manually inspected to identify relevant works that may not have been captured by the initial keyword search.

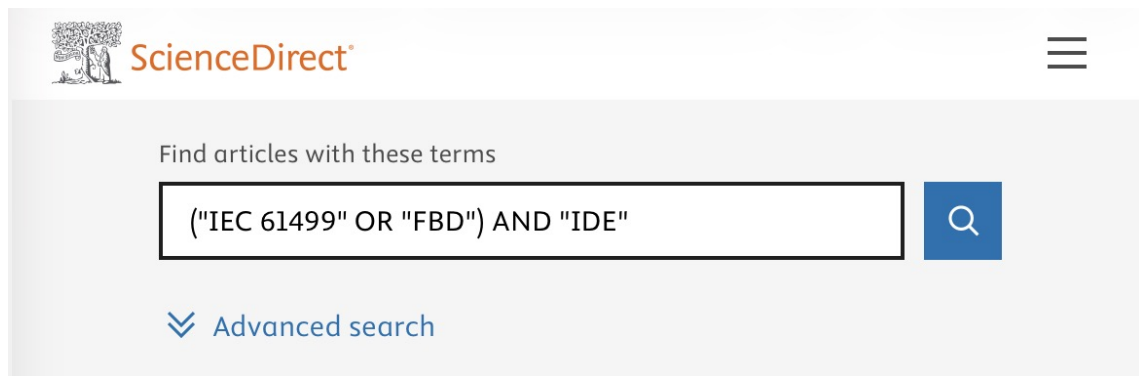


Figure 2.1: Example query on *ScienceDirect* with 136 results [10]

Furthermore, terms related to the state of the art that were discovered mid search were also included in some queries. The objectives of doing this were to get a better personal understanding of the scene, as well as to find interesting references that could be included in this dissertation to backup the written claims. Some of the terms used were:

- PLC
- 4diac
- web-based

2.2 Related Work

It should be interesting to mention some papers that were used to get the knowledge used for writing this dissertation and which will be referenced throughout the whole document.

Monostori [6] write in-depth about CPPS, while Torres, Gonçalves, and Pinto [12] discuss how *IEC 61499* can be leveraged for CPPS development. Zoitl et al. [16] demonstrated the use of the open-source *4DIAC* environment to develop modular and reusable *IEC 61499* applications, highlighting the benefits of flexibility and adaptability in industrial settings. Similarly, Pinto et al. [8] presented an industrial case study showing that function blocks oriented approaches improve system modularity and reduce development effort compared to traditional procedural programming. Some more recent studies explore web-based execution of FBD, Rohat and Popescu [9] as well as Lyu et al. [5] propose the creation of a web platform for *IEC 61499* development.

Chapter 3

State of the Art

This chapter provides a comprehensive analysis of the current landscape of development environments for **CPPS** and the *IEC 61499* standard. It categorizes existing solutions into desktop-based and web-based development tools, while analyzing a possible gap in the ecosystem.

3.1 Development Ecosystem

Currently, the development ecosystem is dominated by desktop-based **IDEs**. These tools are typically monolithic applications installed locally on engineering workstations.

3.1.1 Open-Source

The most prominent open-source implementation is the *Eclipse 4diac* framework. It consists of the *4diac IDE* (based on the *Eclipse* framework) and the *4diac FORTE* (a run-time environment), although it can also use different **RTEs** like *DINASORE*. This **IDE** is very feature rich at the cost of significant system resources and increased complexity, resulting in a steep learning curve, which makes it more difficult to use [14].

An alternative is *Jetbrains FBME* which is a much simpler modeling environment which also relies on *4diac FORTE* as the **RTE** [11].



Figure 3.1: *4diac* logo



Figure 3.2: DINASORE logo

3.1.2 Commercial

The commercial side is dominated by *EcoStruxure Automation Expert*, *ISaGRAF Workbench* and other monolithic desktop based environments, usually with a built-in proprietary RTE. This makes them often very complete production ready tools, but they are not very flexible and not the best fit for many needs.

3.2 Evolution of Web-Based Engineering Tools

The software engineering domain has seen a massive shift from desktop IDEs to cloud-native environments. This trend is now influencing the domain of Industrial Control Systems (ICS), and while recent studies have proposed a Service-Oriented Architectures (SOA) to integrate IEC 61499 with cloud layers [12], the engineering tools themselves remain largely desktop-bound.

3.2.1 Web-Based IDEs in Software Development

In general software development, tools like *Visual Studio Code* have started offering web-based counterparts (as seen in Figure 3.3) to their desktop applications [13] in search of a more flexible user experience. In fact, newer development environments like *Zed* make it a key goal of their products to have web platform support [15].

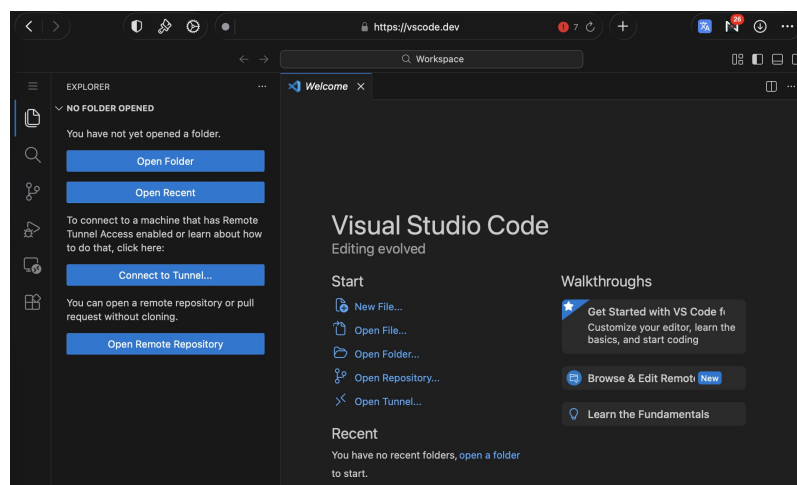


Figure 3.3: VSCode Web interface

3.3 Gap Analysis

Current *IEC 61499* tools face significant limitations that hinder modern **CPPS** development:

- **Platform Dependency:** Existing solutions are monolithic desktop applications, lacking the accessibility and portability of web-based environments.
- **Resource Intensity:** Current options are heavyweight and complex, creating a high barrier to entry compared modern development tools of other purposes.
- **Web Trends:** Despite industry trends, there is currently no mature, lightweight web interface for **FBD**, leaving **ICS** engineering behind the curve of cloud-native software development.

Chapter 4

Proposed Solution

To address the limitations identified in existing *IEC 61499* development environments, this dissertation proposes the design and implementation of a lightweight, web-based **IDE** for *IEC 61499*-compliant applications. The proposed solution leverages modern web technologies to provide a platform-independent, accessible, and collaborative environment for designing, validating, and deploying **FBD** control logic. This solution aims to reduce setup complexity and lower the entry barrier for new users for **CPPS** development workflows. This work seeks to bridge the gap between modern software engineering practices and the current state of industrial automation tooling for **CPPS**.

4.1 Approach

Based on the identified gaps in the literature and state of the art, the proposed solution focuses on the development of a lightweight, web-based **IDE** for modeling *IEC 61499*-compliant **FBD**. The approach begins with the derivation of functional and non-functional requirements from the *IEC 61499* standard and an analysis of existing desktop-based tools. Core requirements include support for function block types, function block networks, event and data connections, and deployment to compliant runtime environments, namely *DINASORE*. Non-functional requirements emphasize platform independence, reduced complexity, usability, and extensibility, addressing the resource intensity and accessibility issues of current solutions. The use of modern web technologies further allows the inclusion of collaborative features and scalable workflows, which are largely absent from current *IEC 61499* tools.

The effectiveness of the approach is assessed through the implementation of a functional prototype and its direct comparison with established desktop-based **IDEs** like *4diac*, focusing on usability, accessibility, and workflow efficiency. This evaluation demonstrates the feasibility of applying web-based engineering principles to *IEC 61499* development and their potential benefits for distributed **CPPS**.

4.2 Methods

This section describes the research methodology adopted to address the research questions defined in this dissertation. Given the practical and design-oriented nature of the problem, the methodology focuses on the design, implementation, and evaluation of a piece of software. The chosen methods are appropriate for investigating how web-based technologies can enhance *IEC 61499* development environments, as they allow both the realization of a concrete solution and the systematic assessment of its capabilities relative to existing tools.

4.2.1 Research Design

This research follows a qualitative, design-oriented research approach. The core of the research consists of the design and implementation of a functional prototype of the solution. Rather than aiming for statistical generalization, the study focuses on demonstrating feasibility and identifying qualitative improvements over existing desktop-based environments. The prototype serves as a research artifact used to explore architectural decisions, usability considerations, and workflow implications.

4.2.2 Evaluation

Evaluation is conducted through qualitative analysis and comparative assessment against established *IEC 61499 IDEs*. Criteria such as accessibility, usability, feature coverage, and support for collaborative workflows are used to assess how effectively the proposed solution addresses the limitations identified in the literature and state of the art.

4.3 Workplan

Figure 4.1 outlines the planned work for this dissertation. The schedule is organized into three main phases: Experimentation, Code Development, and Deliveries. During the Experimentation phase, there will be a focus on studying the standard and running experiments to establish a solid technical foundation. The Code Development phase overlaps partially with Experimentation, ensuring that the software evolves in parallel with the experimental insights. Finally, the Deliveries phase spans the entire project duration and includes writing the dissertation and preparing the final presentation, ensuring that all outputs are documented and communicated effectively.

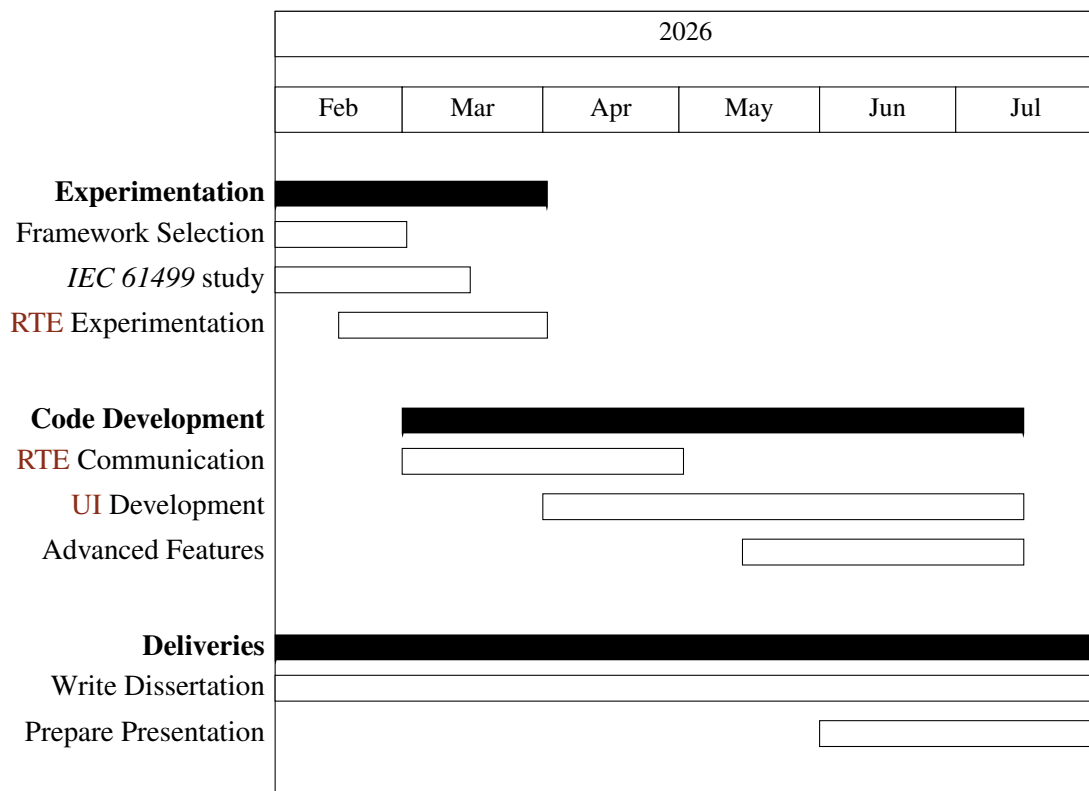


Figure 4.1: Gantt chart timeline for the proposed work

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